Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Steve Buckingham

Steve Buckingham has lead a storied life in the music business, first as an in-demand studio guitarist and subsequently as a highly successful producer and record company executive. He has earned four Grammy awards and been involved with 20 gold and 12 platinum records.

Steve was interviewed in Clinton, New York on February 25, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Steve Buckingham on campus today at Hamilton College. Thanks for being here.

SB: It's nice to be here, in a blizzard or whatever this is.

MR: It is really quite annoying outside, yes.

SB: But it's a beautiful campus. Coming in last night it looked like a Currier & Ives card, so yeah.

MR: Well you've got quite a lengthy resume and we're not going to get through all of it, but I wanted to talk first about session musicians. I've been lucky to interview some fairly well known producers, a fellow named Joel Dorn, George Avakian. They were not — they didn't play instruments. And I'm wondering if your own, being a guitarist and starting out as a session musician has informed your production choices and skills.

SB: Well it helped me but I can tell you many producers, who are not musicians or were not musicians, Rick Hall in Muscle Shoals, Alabama could play but he wasn't a great musician, but he was a great producer. I've known him, like I say if you talk to ten of us, how we got into it, you'll get ten different stories. I actually didn't start as a session player. I came from Richmond, Virginia, and when I was 14 we started a band, some friends, we started a little five piece band because of the Beatles. But by the time I was 19, and our band, we expanded into a big nine piece band. Big horn section. An R&B band. And we got on the circuit of backing a lot of black artists like Jackie Wilson, the Impressions, and so on. And we would be their back-up band through Virginia or North Carolina and South Carolina. So the Drifters, who carried just the guitar player, I don't know his name but he was amazing, from New York. So I got to play with a lot of those people as a teenager. But when I was 19 our band went to Baltimore to record a record, a single. And the engineer was George Massenburg, who is my longest friend in the business, 50 years now. George, besides being a world-renown engineer, invented a lot of the equipment that's used in studios, parametric equalization and so on. George and I became friends that one day in '69 and he asked me, it was a Sunday. He said everybody else has to go back to go to school, which I was supposed to do, go back to the University

of Richmond on Monday morning. So everybody went back but me. He said, "Do you want to stay over and watch me mix tomorrow? Monday morning. I said yeah. So I stayed over, go to the studio on Monday morning and we're in one studio, in Baltimore and this was of course four track recording. And in another studio across the hall I saw these guys walking in with guitar cases and stuff, I said, "Who are they?" He said, "They're studio musicians." He said they're here to play on somebody's record or a jingle or something like that. And like the light bulb goes off. I took the bus home from Baltimore to Richmond with the tape. I told my parents I wanted to become a studio guitar player. And they said just finish college and you can do whatever you want. And I did. But I started playing in sessions while I was still in college.

MR: Did you read music?

SB: I taught myself theory and how to read. I worked in a music store in Richmond, Don Warner Music, and Don Warner gave me a book on music theory, a little thin book like this, and I taught myself theory, taught myself to read, I taught guitar. I'd stay about two weeks ahead of my students at that time. I was a teenager. But then I started buying books, oh heck, different books on theory to teach myself. And I could read when I was really playing sessions every day, seven days a week. You know you had to learn those kind of charts. But especially in Nashville, Memphis, Muscle Shoals, number charts. I've got some examples I'll show you. But — do you know about number charts?

MR: I think I do but I'd like you to —

SB: We just called it number charts but they called it the Nashville Number System. It was actually started by a vocal group called the Jordanaires.

MR: They played with Elvis, right?

SB: Oh they sang with everybody. Elvis, Ricky Nelson, everybody. But they developed that thing where they would listen to a tune, a demo, and the lyric sheet would be in it, and over every note they would write 1, 4, 6 minor, which in the key of C you're talking about C, 4 would be F, 6 minor would be A minor, it's all relative. Everybody, every studio musician, if they didn't have perfect pitch they had perfect relative pitch. You give them the root note and hit the next and they'll tell you if it's a 3, 4, 5, 6 minor and so on. It became very complicated with flatted ninths and all that sort of thing. But it was all written out in numbers. I can show you some charts later. So I learned early to read number charts, which, when you went to Muscle Shoals and those kind of places early on in my career you had to read numbers. You had to write your own charts. They played the demo and everybody would get to their pad and you'd write just 1, 3, 3 minor, 4, 6 minor, whatever, you'd write your basic chart out and then you'd make notes for yourself.

MR: How did you divide the work up, because usually you had multiple guitar players on a session?

SB: Sometimes. Usually two. Sometimes one. Some sessions three. I worked in LA with Tommy Tedesco, the Wrecking Crew, all those guys. And they could all read. That's when they say, "they could read flypaper." Tedesco could read charts upside down. He could play charts upside — literally turn it over and play it backwards. He could read anything. But that's when I first heard of Glen Campbell. He was one of the Wrecking Crew. He could not read but he had such great ears. If he heard it one time he could play it back. But he's one of the greatest studio guitar players I ever heard. So was Tedesco. But they were all — they could — if you've ever heard stuff Glen Campbell did — he could play jazz. Tedesco. They could all play jazz. Every great studio musician I've known anywhere could play jazz as well as country, pop, R&B. You had to do it. Not that we played on jazz sessions, but we all loved it so we could play it.

MR: When you went to do a session invariably you're going to be playing music that you might not like. How do you adjust your attitude towards that.

SB: You just have to be professional. You were hired guns and you were only as good as your last record that you were playing on. So it was very competitive. Everybody wanted to be a studio player and very few get through the keyhole. Especially back then. It's not so that way — it's almost a nonexistent art now because the way people make records they very seldom hire studio musicians. In Nashville they do but not like it used to be. It used to be literally three sessions, sometimes four sessions a day, six or seven days a week. We would work all the time. And there was a generation or two ahead of us from the late 50s through the 60s, the Wrecking Crew in LA, every major recording center had one or two rhythm sections. LA it was the Wrecking Crew, which was a loosely knit group of great players, usually three guitars, two keyboardists, electric bass, an upright bass, multiple instrumentalists. And Nashville it was the A team, the historic A team that played on the Owen Bradley/Patsy Cline records and all those things for Chet [Atkins]. But I mean one of the great guitarists back in those days in the 60s was a fellow named Hank Garland. He played on "Rockin' Around the Christmas Tree" and all that kind of stuff, but he did a jazz album called "Jazz Winds from a New Direction" I think. And it was Joe Morello and oh my gosh the great vibraphone player, a young guy back then, but it was jazz players from New York and he cut this great jazz album. They could all play jazz. Chet could play jazz.

MR: When you were doing this work as a session musician, were you like eyeing the producer and soaking that in?

SB: Yeah. The good ones and the bad ones. Well yeah, there were days you showed up and it was just routine but you had to be professional like I was going to say, and it was the task

at hand. You walk in, you hear the demo, they either handed you a chart or you wrote your own chart, and you would run it down one time. If there were mistakes, make your notes what you were supposed to do. And then you would usually get it, and me as a producer too, but the players I'd work with, you'd get it in usually the first, second or third take. You had to. If it took longer than that then you're running — sessions are divided into three hour segments, usually 10 in the morning to 1, one hour break, 2 until 5, 6 to 9, and then if there was a fourth it would be 10 to 1 in the morning, which we loved, because after midnight you got paid triple scale or something. We were double scale musicians. Some guys got so busy, especially in LA, like Larry Carlton, they started charging triple scale to try to discourage the sessions, but they still got hired. But they were so good. And again, like Larry can play anything.

MR: When you became a producer, and I'm thinking about people coming out of music schools and so forth, and they wanted to get into this whatever is left of the business — you assume that these musicians are good players but what else do they have to bring or not bring in order to keep getting hired again.

SB: That's a good thing you just said, "or not bring." One of the great session guitarists of all time who just died in January, Reggie Young, who played on thousands of records, "Son of a Preacher Man," Dusty Springfield, "Drift Away" Dobie Gray. Reggie was one of my idols. And one time he told me, it's what you don't play. And another, I can't remember who it was said, "Air is a note too." Open space is a note. And Reggie, that was one of his things I learned. It's what you don't play. You don't play all over the place. That's where most people make their mistake. They come in and like look what I can do. It's — you have to play as an ensemble immediately. Now there's guys you have worked with in most cases, but in some cases you've not worked with them but you have to come together, literally, on the rundown, as a band. You have to be a band like you're played together for years together, on the rundown. And you have to be an ensemble immediately. And that's what separates the ones who want to do it from the ones who did it. I think that's one of the things. There are more things.

MR: And you'd usually hear a demo, but when you were recording the background track —

SB: The rhythm track.

MR: The rhythm track, were you hearing a singer?

SB: Yes. If it wasn't the artist there would be somebody in there, they called it, "the scratch vocal." Usually the artist was there. I can think of only a few occasions if something happened and we had to cut a track without the artist being there. The artist was always there. Anywhere. On either coast. And yeah, they'd be in the booth doing their scratch vocal, but a lot of times we would nail it on the first take. The rundown. And we'd do a second. We'd do the rundown, then take 1, take 2, and go back and keep the rundown.

MR: It's something that —

SB: And sometimes the vocals were that way too.

MR: No kidding.

SB: Just right off the floor.

MR: Everybody playing at the same time.

SB: Yeah. And if you've seen "Standing in the Shadows of Motown" where everybody was crammed in that one room, and sometimes with strings and brass and background singers, I mean just crammed into one room, and they weren't wearing headphones. By the time I started playing everybody was wearing headphones. We'd be in a room together and usually it was a five piece rhythm section, six piece rhythm section, but I also did things where we were live with strings and — sometimes strings, brass and woodwinds. And that was in LA for big dates. And you just — you can't screw up. You don't want to be the guy that makes them start over again. Especially, I came along when there were still guys playing when it was direct to disk. And if you screwed up it goes in the trash can. Put another disk on and cut — it was not going to tape in the old old days, it was going to disk. A lacquer. And literally they'd be throwing them in the trash can the guys told me. And I did some direct to disc recording in LA and I mean always the pressure was on but you didn't show it and you just had to deliver really quick. And that's another thing, it's the quick mind, the quick inventive mind, creative mind. You'd have to create those licks, memorable licks, on the spot. Especially guitar players and keyboard players.

MR: So what happens if a producer comes out and maybe they played guitar once and they're trying to tell you, you know, do it like this and they're holding their hands out and they're going like that. And you know that that's not the thing to do.

SB: Yup. Many times. I learned as much from the great producers — the bad producers — as I did from the great producers. What not to do. I could play. A lot of producers couldn't play. But there were also some great producers who didn't play. But oh gosh I've had them stand there in front of me humming something that had nothing to do with the track, the demo or the track. And you just nod and then you do it the way you know it should be done. And then you go in the control and you go, "Thanks for that input. Thanks for that direction." Because I've always said a producer in music is more like a film director. You pick the location, (the studio), you pick the tech crew (your engineers), you pick the musicians, who are like bit players, and the artist is the artist, and the script is the song, the lyrics. It's a misnomer. A music producer is more like a film director in music. That's it in a nutshell.

MR: I'm glad you brought that up. Orrin Keepnews described himself as a catalytic agent.

SB: That's good. You have to be as a producer, yeah. You have to walk that tightrope between a creative artist and these highly accomplished musicians, and the technical

guys. You've got to know the tech — and back then the technical part — like I was telling this class today here, the recording class, you know we recorded on this giant analog consoles, which are still the best. Well when I first started it was four track, then we went to George Massenburg and I went to Philadelphia to record at Sigma Sound because they had an eight track. But I started out on four track, then eight, then sixteen, then twenty-four, and then the digital stuff came in. But I was showing pictures today from the old days of those giant consoles which still are — in just a few studios today because they're dinosaurs. And they're so expensive. I was telling today, the mics in these studios, they'd have over a million dollars in microphones, just vintage microphones. And all the engineers that I've worked with — well it's only been a few that I've worked with consistently, and they had their own racks of gear that would be wheeled into the studio in the control room. You know, equalization, compression, the mic preamps, the microphones. But most of the great studios, like Capitol in LA had millions of dollars — and still do — millions of dollars in vintage microphones. A single mic, like a classic Neumann or Telefunken or whatever, it could be fifteen grand there. A single microphone. So people trying to record now couldn't afford a console that would stretch from the wall over to here and take three of us at the console. Nobody can afford that now.

MR: So does unlimited digital tracks necessarily make for better music?

SB: No. No. Because we made great records. The Beatles cut Sgt. Pepper's on a four-track, I think synced to another four track. And it was the technique, if you had four tracks, track one might be like George Martin with the Beatles. Track one might be McCartney and Ringo. They'd mix the drums and the bass on track one. Track two might be — would be the guitars and the bass mixed together. But you had to get all those levels set before you recorded. And then here's track one, bass and drums. All the drums. You know it came to the point where we were using eight tracks just to record drums, and still do. But mix the bass and drums, the guitars and keyboard, here's a vocal on track three. You'd leave track four open. And then to open up new tracks you'd bounce it down they called it. You'd mix track one with track two — the bass, drums and the guitars, bounce them over to track four and you'd open up two tracks here to put whatever, background vocals, a sax or something that wasn't on the date. And then you'd keep bouncing things. Of course in analog, every time you bounce from one track to another you lose a generation so the sound degrades a little bit. But that's the only way you could do it. So that's what they did like George Martin with the Beatles. Bouncing tracks to open up new tracks. Because if you listen to that stuff, obviously it's multiple tracks of things. And that was when it was just four tracks, two four track machines synced together and eventually an eight track machine. But I don't think they ever recorded — well maybe later, in the late 60s

before they broke up they may have been on a sixteen track. But now when you say does more tracks make it — no. But it just gives you more stuff to put on there and try to filter your way through. And somebody asked me today in this recording class, the sound now as opposed to then. I said well everybody now listens with ear buds through their cell phone or computer, and it has to be compressed so much. And that sound back then — in my home music room I've got 1969 JBL speakers this tall, and that's the way I like to listen, like in the control room. I can't stand this sound because it's so compressed, and it's squashed down. It's totally different. But that's all anybody — there's no yardstick now like it used to be. You had to make your records sound as good as Tom Dowd in New York or Al Schmidt in LA or something like that.

MR: Yeah I can remember some producers saying you've got to keep in mind that a lot of people are going to listen to this in their two inch speakers in their car. So they would do a mix where they were just listening to these very small monitors.

SB: Yeah we still do. We have — in the control room you have the big built-in monitors in the wall, these huge custom-made things. And then you have the mid-field, speakers maybe about that tall sitting out in front of the console. And then up on your console you'd have two usually Yamaha NS 10 speakers about like, the near-field monitors. But in the center of the console we used to do it because when you're talking about two speakers in a car, you remember, when I was started it was one speaker, it was mono in the car. So in the center of the console we had a little square speaker called an Auratone.

MR: Oh yes, the Auratones.

SB: And we would hear that up there, the big sound; listen to the mid-range; the near-field monitors; and then we'd listen to the little Auratones to make sure — the main thing you had to make sure was that the vocal was up above the music.

MR: I'm so glad you brought that up. I'm showing my age. But if I have the 60s channel on and I'm hearing any number of things, Dusty Springfield or anything, like there's no straining to hear what she's saying. Now if I turn on current music and you know, here we go, current music, but I'm always straining, even with maybe Tom Petty or those kind of people. What's he saying. Like I'm listening hard. Is it your feeling that the music and the bass have come up and the vocal hasn't come with it?

SB: You've got to understand where it's going now. It's all compressed so much. It squashes all the music and the vocal. But Tom Petty at least recorded in real studios. Now it's people who are trying to get in the business are doing it on their computers with all the plug-ins, where we had millions of dollars of equipment in the control room, now you can access a similar sound on the computer. But one of the things — I mean this goes back to the 40s with Sinatra and people. The vocal had to be here and the music had to be here. And we would listen really — I never listened really loud in the control room, ever.

Even as a studio player, I always listened at a really low level to hear where the vocal was sitting. More so than everything else. Everything else we could kind of mix ourselves as musicians. But you had to make sure the vocal was just right — I always said I strived to make records that were transparent. That you could walk into the mix and it would surround you. And that's gone. Because everything is so compressed now. There's a few people that make records like that but we took our cue from those days — the Sinatra days. Capitol Records. Nat Cole. Peggy Lee. Sinatra. All those people. I mean I've worked in that studio which thank God they made into a landmark so they can't tear it up, like most of them are gone.

MR: Okay. Here's two phrases I've heard in the studio work I was able to do: "We'll fix it in the mix."

SB: Bad. No it either comes off the floor as we say, comes off the floor with the musicians. It's got to be there off the floor. Fix it in the mix is like vocal tuning. You know what a vocal tuner is. Everybody uses vocal tuning now. Tuning the vocals. Which I never did because I always worked with artists who — first of all I don't like the sound of vocal tuning. People have gotten to the point where they use it almost as an effect on the vocal. Vocals are tuned to death. I can hear it immediately. And they use it almost as an effect now. And not only that, the vocals are artificially doubled or tripled, the lead vocals, in so many things I hear. I can't handle it. When I'm in a restaurant I have to get up and leave. I'm not putting it down — it's just now what I grew up — here I did I just hit the mic. I'm expressive. But anyway, no, fixing in the mix is BS. If it's not there off the floor immediately you can't fix it in the — well for us you couldn't fix it in the mix. It had to be right from the start.

MR: Okay, the other one was, like if you're doing overdubs and you do it and the producer says, "That was perfect let's do another one."

SB: Oh I went through that, but most of the producers, when I was a session player, most of the producers I worked with luckily were great producers, and they knew to cut and capture the spontaneity. That's what I always tried to do. That's why when I was starting out as a producer I knew when they were running down the chart, I would always record the rundown and then we'd do take one, take two, maybe a take three. And I'll tell you it was a lot of times I used the rundown and the scratch vocal. But we never — I can't think of any time, as a player or as a producer, that I went more than three takes. The rundown and three takes, it had to be. Because you were trying — as they said — one of the expressions, it is true, time is money. And in those days time really was money. You were paying those studio musicians, you were paying for that studio and you were paying for those engineers and the clock was running as I said, and in the old days a light would come on when it was time to record this recording — this red light. And people would, if

they weren't used to it they'd freak out as soon as the light went on they said. They couldn't handle it. They could play until the light went on and then they froze up. But they did away with the light as we used to call it. But you could see it. It would reflect all around in the windows in the control room, that the light was on.

MR: I see. Who needs that kind of pressure?

SB: Yeah well you learn to do it. But some people couldn't do it when the light went on.

MR: Fascinating stuff. As a producer, we talked about liking or disliking music as a session musician and it doesn't really matter. You have to play everything equally as well. As a producer, have you been in situations were you were hired to produce music that you didn't like, or —

SB: No. Go ahead I'm sorry.

MR: Or an artist that you didn't really get along with.

SB: No. There's only been, gosh I produced my first record in 1977 and I can only think of two times, no maybe once there was an artist on Capitol in LA and I'd heard a record that she had made by a well respected at that time, very rare female producer in Philadelphia, who has passed away, Linda Creed. Great producer. And I heard this record that Linda Creed had done on this female artist. And then Capitol said they wanted me to produce an album on her. And I went out and met with her in LA, went over songs, went over the keys. But she never would sing — like I was always kind of leaning in, like I can't quite hear how she really sounds. And the first day we got in the studio it was a train wreck. And I mean I had the best players, engineers, studio, everything. But it wasn't there. Fixing that in the mix, no. You couldn't fix something like that. And I went home, I called the session early and went home. I called Linda Creed in Philadelphia and I said, "I'm working on this thing" with so-and-so, and I said, "I heard the album you did on her." And she said, "How far are you into it?" I said, "I called the session early today." She said, "Get out now." And that's the only session I can ever remember that I stopped and called Capitol and said this is a fraud. The artist obviously will remain nameless, but the other thing, when you're saying did I do things with people I didn't get along with or music I didn't like, I just didn't take those projects. I didn't take them. I only worked with the people I really wanted to work with.

MR: Did you ever have a significant recording done and had an investment in this session and it turns out the singer couldn't cut it and bring in another singer?

SB: No. The closest I came to that was a female trio from Motown, not the Supremes, and again I'd heard an album they had done and I wanted to do it because I was doing a lot of stuff for Motown then, Smokey Robinson and Berry Gordy and all this kind of stuff. So I wanted to do — I was doing Motown sessions as a producer. And this trio though, on the first song you realized they can't do it. So I actually recorded them, we did the session

and I wanted to please Smokey, because he was kind of the unofficial head of A&R at Motown when they had — well in Detroit as well as in LA. This is when they were in LA. And I wanted to do it for Barry — I was doing it for Smokey Robinson. I wanted to please Smokey Robinson, because he's a great writer and producer and artist. And so I brought in ringers out in LA. There was a great background vocal group called the Water Sisters and I used them on lots of records. And that entire album is basically — maybe that lead singer from that trio, but it's basically the Water Sisters. And they know it. It was not uncommon for something like that to happen. That's the only — the one I told you about and that one is the only two times. And the reason I stuck with that was because I wanted to please Smokey Robinson. I did other records, Bettye LaVette and other people from Motown, and it was to get Smokey's seal of approval. That was a big deal. Because here's a guy who wrote and produced "My Girl" for the Temptations among all the other stuff he did with the Miracles and his group. An amazing artist and producer and writer. I wanted to please Smoky.

MR: Do you have a built-in detection system for things that you or other people might want to include on a song, like a really cool part, or let's put a lute on it or something, and it sounds like a good idea but it's not relevant to the song.

SB: I can't think of anything like that. I always kept a legal pad in front of me when I was producing. I took some of my pads today for them to see where each song, I'd have intro, verse one, sometimes you'd have a bridge going to the chorus or a channel we call it going to the chorus, then there'd be a short turnaround, then the second verse. And so I'd have each song, I'd write as they were recording, I'd write down who would do the fills here, where would the piano fill halfway through the first verse. Where would the guitar do a fill? Because that's the whole thing about studio playing is the fills in between the vocals. If you listen to great records, those guys are not just noodling all the way through the song. They're laying back until it's that space for them to do their fill, whether it's a piano lick or a guitar lick. But I would also make notes for overdubs like sax, solo or, usually it would be a solo, something like alto. The first record I ever produced, "I Love the Night Life" which by the grace of God became a hit all over the world. I did that modulation in that alto sax solo.

MR: I can hear it now that you said that, yeah.

SB: And I told them I said I want this to sound like New York on a rainy night. And if you listen to that alto solo, it was by a guy named Jay Scott, who couldn't read music, but he had an amazing sound. And he did that thing with the alto and the tenor at the same time and all that sort of thing. Not in the studio of course. But he could do it. But that alto solo in "Night Life" I just said, "wet streets of New York." And that was I think the second take, that solo. That was an overdub. It wasn't off the floor live. But as far as, I don't

think I ever added a lute to anything but at some times I'd make a note for an English horn or a bassoon or something like that. That would be the orchestra dates. And then whatever the instrument I wanted to feature, sometimes a couple of French horns or something like that, we'd have to mic certain ways. There's a real technique to micing a string section in an orchestra, brass and woodwinds, that type of thing. But I would make notes about — I'd put bassoon question mark you know, and then we'd come back. And I did the orchestra dates in LA. That's where I added that sort of thing. I don't think I ever added a lute to anything. I know I've worked with Irish groups and we had the pennywhistles and the whistles and the uilleann pipes and all that kind of stuff. If I had a lute on a song I'm not familiar with it.

MR: Okay. When you get contracted or hired to produce a record with a person you have never met, or I guess I should ask first, has that happened?

SB: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

SB: But you would end up meeting them way before you go in the studio.

MR: That's my question, like what's the first interaction like?

SB: A meeting. After I did "I Love the Night Life" the next person to call me was Clive Davis and flew me to New York and he quizzed me. He played me demos of songs. He'd play me records that they were getting ready to release. And he would be very specific. "Do you think this is a hit? Why or why not?" He was very specific and we were there hours the first time I met with Clive in New York. And we left after that first day and he said, "Put together some songs" he's a song man to this day, he's what 86 or so now, and still the chairman of SONY/BMG or whatever it is now. And he said, "Put together some songs and send them to me." And I did. I got I think six songs together from the few writers I knew. A couple of guys in LA, one guy in Muscle Shoals. And I put together a reel to reel tape back then, it was before cassette, and sent him a reel to reel of six songs. And within a couple of days I get a call from a secretary saying, "Come to New York, Clive wants to meet with you." I went to New York and out of the six songs I sent him he loved four of them. And if you've ever worked with Clive Davis, I didn't know it then, but he could go through two hundred songs and turn them all down. He was so critical. He's a real song man. Not a musician, but a song man and a record man. Anyway, we played the four songs and he was asking me my ideas about the production from the demos, the writer's demos. And then he started playing me songs. And I'd say, "I hear that one, I don't hear that." Anyway at the end of that day he said, "I'm flying you tonight to Los Angeles to meet with Melissa Manchester to do her next album." And Melissa was — I did, you meet — well I flew out and met with her manager at her manager's house the next day. And thank goodness it worked. Our first album was

successful, and her second album. And we did a Christmas album in the late 90s. I mean we're still friends. I just went to see her play a few months ago, a couple of months ago. We're still great friends. But that's usually how — you have to meet with them ahead of time to see if there's a chemistry.

MR: What's the first run through of the songs like? Do you have a piano player on hand or did you play your guitar?

SB: Well you mean when I met with like her with the songs?

MR: Yeah.

SB: I had demos. I had demo tapes. Now Melissa is a great piano player but usually when I'd meet with an artist I'd have demo tapes of songs. A lot of times, like with Dolly or somebody, they're great writers. Melissa is a good writer, a great writer. And they would always have input about their songs. And it would be again like yes, no, I hear this I don't hear that one. And it's just a process you go through. And it would be very methodical and very thorough so that when you got to the studio there was not going to be any surprises. You had your material picked. Well you'd always overcut as we said. Because on vinyl you had 17 minutes a side. You could do five or six cuts per side on a vinyl album. After that it just wouldn't hold it on the inside grooves. But you would cut 15 or 16 songs to pick your 10 or 12 on every project I ever did I think. I think, for sure. You cull them out as they say for the end.

MR: Did the things that got culled out ever make it to the next record.

SB: Not that I know of. I know they've done like re-releases on things, later re-releases. Hidden gems.

MR: Hidden gems. Now we have more time on the CD we can pull in —

SB: Yeah. And they do that sort of thing. And occasionally I will hear something that we recorded and mixed but it didn't make the album but it turns up on somebody's hidden gems album or whatever you want to call those things. Unreleased.

MR: It's interesting because there's a few LPs that I loved so much and when they became re-issued on CD they added some songs in, and I didn't like it. It sort of like messed with the whole vibe of the record or something.

SB: I always tried to tell a story with an album. You put the needle on one side, turn it over, needle on, it was a story. Because people did really listen top to bottom, which is a lost art now because everybody listens to a track here or a track there. They download a track or they stream a track, but not an album. It used to be the album had to tell a story musically. It had to be. Going back to when Sinatra started doing that stuff with Nelson Riddle in the 50s. Those were concept albums. Probably the first concept albums, those Sinatra albums with Nelson Riddle at Capitol. He'd been on Columbia and it wasn't

good. Mitch Miller in New York. But when he got with Capitol in LA and especially with Nelson Riddle and Axel Stordahl and oh the great trumpet player.

MR: Billy May.

SB: Billy May. Oh my gosh those are phenomenal concept records. You put on "Wee Small Hours," any of those albums, you drop a needle and go all the way through and it's a story. It's a novel.

MR: It's very interesting, the fact that a lot of the sidemen, the swing musicians, after the big band era petered out, that they could walk into those studios and work. They were skilled enough to make that happen.

SB: Yup. In New York and LA. And I was lucky enough to come along when there were still a lot of those guys around, the brass, woodwinds, and the string players. They were old Hollywood guys. They played on the movies going back into the late 40s and 50s. And they were phenomenal. You had a concert master and it was for real. And we usually cut our strings 12-4-4-2; 12 violins, 4 violi, 4 celli, 2 double basses, upright basses. And I would have to pay them but once we got that it was really quick with the charts. The main thing was to run it down and correct mistakes in the chart. He'd circle things up on the stand with the conductor and then the copyists would be there, the arranger and they would "on bar 64 change the e to an e flat" for each, if there was a mistake in the charts or something didn't fit right. But then it was always first or second take. And then I would double the strings and sometimes triple them. But we wouldn't just triple them with the same, we'd move the mics a little bit. They were all miced up there like this. Some were close miced. But if there was a little step out with a violin or something we'd close mic that but everything else was overheads. Like a classical orchestra. And you had to get it quick with that many people in the studio. If you had a 12-4-4 and 2 string section, but then if you were adding brass I mean I think the largest section I ever did was maybe 65 pieces at once, including live drums and live bass and live guitar and live piano.

MR: I bet you were holding your breath, right?

SB: You know there's a great engineer/producer out in LA named Al Schmidt who is in his late 80s now. And I think he won a Grammy two years ago. He started out when he was a kid in New York. He's one of the masters of all time. And he recorded in the early 60s Sam Cooke and people like that, up through Norah Jones. He's still winning Grammys. He's won I think 20, 22 Grammys. And Al told me one time, when I had one of those big dates, a roomful of players, one of the words of wisdom, "Just don't let them see you sweat." You always have to act confident. You can't let them see that you're nervous. I don't care if it's four people out there or 64 people out there, you can't let them see you sweat. You've got to act confident. Even if you think oh my God. And I've had times

when there was 35 people sitting out there and the tape machine would break right before the session, and we'd have to sit there for an hour. You're looking at your watch and they're looking at their watches. Because they know they're only there for three hours; maybe two sessions, six hours. And you've got to get it. And the tape machine broke one time and we wasted an hour while they fixed that. The studio is not going to pay for those musicians. But we had to cram into two hours what we would have done in three hours. But usually we'd get dates, string dates done, orchestra dates, we'd get three or four songs in a three hour session. And the same way with the rhythm section. We would almost always get at least three songs in a three hour session. That was just expected of you. And those guys that came out of the old Hollywood days or the old New York days, those big band players — I knew guys, there were guys that played with Glenn Miller, Tommy Dorsey, all these guys, that ended up in LA particularly, playing on movie dates. And of course not only were they great musicians but the stories they had, just unbelievable. A good friend of mine, I'm sure you've heard of the piano player and composer Mel Powell? When he was 18 years old he was hired by Benny Goodman to replace Teddy Wilson. And Mel Powell and I became great friends in the early 90s. He couldn't play anymore. He had a degenerative nerve thing. But he said, oh that's okay. He said, "Paul Hindemith taught me to compose here not here." In fact it was Paul Hindemith — I bought three of his theory books when I was starting out, and that's how I learned theory was Hindemith. That's the name I was trying to come up with. Anyways, "Hindemith taught me to compose here not here." So he was still composing. But if you listen to those old Goodman records with Peggy Lee and Mel Powell on piano, a phenomenal player. And he went from there, he got drafted and Glenn Miller had already gone into the army and he got every big band player, every key guy from Dorsey, Goodman, he had Mel Powell in that Army/Air Force band in Europe. It was like the cream of the big band crop, and I got to know a lot of those guys. And oh my gosh could they play. I mean, they could all play.

MR: Yeah. I had a funny, Manny Albam had a funny anecdote about, I think he was producing the Guess Who.

SB: Who was it?

MR: Manny Albam. Anyway, the band struggled for like two or three days to get the rhythm track down and then he calls in all these pros, guys like Bill Watrous. And the band is going, "How did they do that?" And he goes, "Well they play music."

SB: Yeah well the thing is there's a lot of records of rock bands of the day — the Beatles played their own stuff of course, but there were some well known bands that were ghosted as they say. It was the Wrecking Crew in LA on a lot of pop and rock records that were supposed to be the band playing. I won't tell you who, but you can find out. But

it was the same thing. Do you want to spend three days trying to cut a mediocre track or 20 minutes to cut an exceptional track. Guess what wins. But there were millions of dollars spent, tens of millions spent on bands trying to cut their own tracks. I mean there were some certainly that could, but even like things like the Byrds. I mean they played but hey guess who also was in there playing 12-string? Glen Campbell as a session player. But that just comes with the territory. You don't think okay they're out there millions of dollars, I'm in here making double scale. And they're getting royalties, I'm not getting royalties. But that was your job.

MR: Did you ever — this is an odd question, but — did you ever have to break up any fist fights or the like?

SB: Not with musicians. I did among artists on TV shows. There was a TV show called "Midnight Special" back in the old days. And again, I won't go into who — it was two female artists and I was in the control room and I heard this commotion and literally they were out there duking it out in the hallway and I did have to get in the middle of that one. But no, not among the musicians and certainly professional artists, nothing like that. That was the only time. There were times I had to call someone aside and tell them they weren't in shape to play on the date that day for various reasons. And I just said call it a day. Sign the card, the session card. "You'll still get paid but you need to pack it in today." It would usually be for what you can imagine: drugs, alcohol.

MR: Yeah and if they did that too many times.

SB: That's it. Bad news travels fast.

MR: Some of the guys were even telling me that if they had to go out of town they tried not to let people know because as a session musician if your phone rings and you don't pick ups then —

SB: Yeah. Well it was so busy back then, everybody had an answering service. And after every session, everybody'd be out in the hall on the — not cell phones — on the pay phones, calling their service to see what dates were booked for them the next day or the next week or that type of thing. And they'd be writing in their book. And that's where Cartage Company started up in LA because guys like Hal Blaine, the drummer from the Wrecking Crew and those people, they had so many sessions. They may do a 10:00 session for whoever, but their 2:00 session might be a different artist in another studio. So to get the drum set from here over to the next studio, set up and miced, it was those guys who started thinking about, okay I'll have three sets of drums. And while they're playing that session the Cartage Companies with the big trucks would take the equipment trunks to the next studio and they would set up the drums and the engineers could mic it, so Hal Blaine could play drums over at Sunset Sound in the morning, take his lunch break, and

at 2:00 he'd be at United Western Studio with his other drum set already set up. And maybe at 6:00 it'd be the third studio with his third drum set. That's the way it was.

MR: Did the studios or the record companies ever try to lock some of these people in? Like, "We just want you to work for us."

SB: Oh yeah. But not in LA. In Muscle Shoals there was a great producer, Rick Hall, who died a year or two ago. And Rick had his studio. It's still there. His grandson runs it I think. FAME. Florence, Alabama Music Enterprises. And Rick, that's where Aretha went to cut the first hits on Atlantic. She was on Columbia and never had a hit but she got to Atlantic and bam, "I Never Loved a Man the Way I Love You." It was at Rick's studio, although Jerry Wexler produced it. Tom Dowd engineered it, came down from New York. But Rick locked his rhythm section in. The FAME gang they called them. And then some of them broke off and started Muscle Shoals Sound, which didn't go over well with Rick but they all made up in the end. But they were players that started with Rick. And Rick was a big influence. I played sessions for him. We always said if you can play a session for Rick Hall you can play for anybody in the world. He was so tough. And he would hire — you'd show up, and it was not uncommon, there'd be three or four guitar players, two drummers, two keyboard players, a couple of bass players. And literally you'd sit out there, if you were in there and he didn't like what you were doing after a couple of takes, bring in the next guy. And here comes the other guitar player and sits down with his amp and guitars. And I mean he was tough. I mean I saw seasoned session players leave sessions for Rick in tears. But he got what he wanted. And he cut too many hits for it to be an accident. He was a great producer. And I learned so much from Rick. But he tried to lock in his players but they all branched out to form Muscle Shoals Sound and that type of thing. But you couldn't do that with the guys in LA. They were too busy with not only playing record dates but playing movie dates.

MR: Plus the union was —

SB: Well the union was — I mean I've been in the union since 1969. The union had nothing to do with that.

MR: No kidding?

SB: They were paying you no matter what. If you were part of the Muscle Shoals Rhythm Section or you were freelancing. You would go to Muscle Shoals to work with those guys. Everybody went there. Dylan, all these people. But the union — you got paid no matter what. Now scale in the old days was not great — like when I started out — but it got better and better. And then I started paying, like a lot of people — I started as a player I was a double scale musician. Some of the guys, like Larry Carlton, when he was living in LA — he lives in Nashville now — but Larry, he was so busy, seven days a week, he went to triple scale. And some of the others, Tom Scott, the sax player, they all went to

triple scale thinking it would cut back but they kept paying them and they were still working seven days making triple scale instead of double scale.

MR: And then on the other hand there's anecdotes like Jimmy Cobb the drummer who played on "Kind of Blue?" He made like less than a hundred bucks for that thing.

SB: Well scale like I say is much different now. But again not that many people use studio players anymore. Like I say in Nashville the country records, it's still mostly studio guys. I know they still put together jazz groups to play in the studio. But "Kind of Blue," what year was that? Early 60s?

MR: It was '59 I think.

SB: Gosh I doubt if scale then was even 54 bucks.

MR: Yeah I think it was in the 40s or 50s for a three hour session or something.

SB: I think when I started it was like 75 bucks for a three hour session and then I went to double scale.

MR: Do you get unexpected checks in the mail?

SB: Yeah. I don't make royalties as a producer much anymore, but as a player I remember it was a couple of years ago I get this check for 18 thousand dollars out of the blue and I called I guess I called the union, I said, "What in the world is this for?" And it was something I'd played on they had used for an AT&T commercial, a national commercial. We call it mailbox money. Your royalties and stuff like that. But yeah. Every once in a while you get a nice surprise. Those guys, like Carlton and Tom Scott and all them, every year, you get your scale, whatever you were charging, double scale, triple scale, whatever. And then the union has a thing called the Special Payments Fund for recording musicians. And according to how many sessions you played that year, you'd also get your Special Payments check at the end of the year from the union, and it was not uncommon to see some guy drive up in a new Jaguar or something, after a Special Payments check came in. Because they were big checks. You know who Tom Scott is of course.

MR: Of course.

SB: Well he was the highest paid musician for a long time in LA. His Special Payments checks were astronomical. And rightfully so. He was phenomenal. He is phenomenal. But he was the highest paid player in LA for a long, long time. By far. Every year they'd say, "An unnamed reed player in Los Angeles again had the biggest Special Payment check." But everybody knew it was Tom Scott.

MR: That's good info. Well I've got to get in a thing about — I know you're passionate about black music and how it affected bringing the races together.

SB: I taught a course at Vanderbilt for eight years, it's called Rhythm & Blues Tore Down the Walls of Segregation. I'm teaching it now at Virginia/Wesleyan in Virginia Beach where

I live now. I taught it at Vanderbilt for eight years. But yeah, very passionate about that. Because I lived through it in the 60s. My band in Richmond, we became a really popular back-up band for black artists. Back then there were very few artists that carried bands. James Brown had his big 18 piece band and they were like a machine. I get chills just thinking about that, when I first saw that 18 piece, that curtain open up and those guys are in tuxedos. You know. Three drummers, two guitarists, bass player, an organ player, and then everything else was brass and reeds all across the stage in tuxedos. Not just playing but doing the choreography and the whole thing. And then he hits the stage and it's a three hour another world. Ray Charles is one of the ones that had a big 18 piece band, the Ray Charles Orchestra with the Raelettes singing background. Again, that was an experience. But very few black artists could afford that. Like when we played with the Drifters, they brought a guitarist with them from New York — I can't remember his — I don't know his name, but he was phenomenal. But I was playing the second guitar behind him. Jackie Wilson, no band. We just had the charts and we would back the Impressions. Curtis Mayfield was a great guitarist and producer and writer and singer and a great guy, a gentleman. I played second guitar behind Curtis Mayfield, but most black groups, Jackie Wilson, Otis Redding, occasionally Otis would have a band, they would augment it with some of us, and in Virginia and the Carolinas we became like one of the key what, they called it, back-up bands.

MR: Were you an all-white band?

SB: Um hum.

MR: So what kind of things did you witness playing behind these black artists?

SB: Well, the movie the "Green Book" every black artist I knew had the Green Book to know where they could stay, where they could eat. I played with many black artists that we couldn't eat together and we certainly couldn't stay in the same place together. I went with them sometimes and stayed in some of those horrible places they had to stay in. They were bad, bad. But that's just, and it was those towns like they talk about in the "Green Book" you know, sundown towns. They couldn't be out after dark or you had to have a damn good reason if the police stopped you, and they usually did, and if they said we just played a date here. And we had a bus, our band had an old Flexible bus that we had bunks in it and sofas and all that kind of thing back in the day, in the 60s. So they could travel with us. But I don't know how many times we were stopped and they'd get on and they'd see black guys with white kids and it was like hell to pay. I got arrested once in Norfolk, Virginia. We were backing a group from Norfolk called the Showmen, a black quartet or quintet. And it was all white kids dancing. And they raided the place and we got arrested. Not the artists we were backing, we got arrested and our charge was inciting a riot. And it was kids dancing. There was no riot. My father was a First Sergeant

in World War II, boy he drove from Richmond down to Norfolk and he read them the riot act, to get us out of jail. We were arrested more than once. I was, myself. Because I played out with some other groups. But it was bad. Everything you've read about, then double that. It was sometimes scary. But we got through, we're still living. I'll tell you this, we had a pistol on the bus, I did. I know, I don't know if the other band members did but I always had a pistol in my bag. It was some tough things. I — thank God, didn't use it. But everything you saw in the "Green Book" triple that. Yeah. And everything you've read about it, triple that.

MR: Because it wasn't just the police, it would have been the townspeople also, right?

SB: Yeah, they had town councils. And if they saw something about a black artist playing in town, believe me, the town council, the citizens' council, they would call them in like the south. Because I played, besides my band I played places in Georgia and Alabama and Mississippi was really scary. But the citizens' councils they called them, which was just another name basically for the Klan. It really was. And yeah, they came on the bus when I was playing with other people. Or — played one place one night, came out and there was the cross burning outside.

MR: What year would that have been?

SB: '67, '68. Oh yeah. And I had friends who were white disc jockeys in Nashville. There was a big rhythm & blues — the biggest rhythm & blues station in the country was WLAC in Nashville. And they were white disc jockeys. Everybody thought they were black, the way they talked and the music they played. So they were friends of mine. And more than once they burned crosses out in front of WLAC because the white kids were listening to black music and that was a no-no for the town council/citizens' council they called them. It was a front for the Klan basically.

MR: But those kids who were dancing —

SB: Didn't care.

MR: They didn't care, right?

SB: No. That's what I talk about in my class and that's where integration — when John Hammond, who I'm sure you know, knew, or know of — well I was lucky enough to know John Hammond. He worked at two labels, Columbia and Vanguard. I worked at two labels, Columbia and Vanguard. And I got to know Mr. Hammond in the 80s. He died in '87. But he was the guy who integrated the Goodman band in 1935 by getting him to hire Teddy Wilson and then Lionel Hampton and then Charlie Christian. And he told me stories that are just scary, the stuff he ran into. Then he signed Count Basie, then he signed Billie Holiday and on and on, then in the 60s Bob Dylan, Bruce Springsteen.

MR: Aretha?

SB: Well he signed Aretha to Columbia but it was not successful. Columbia took her over and tried to make her into a pop singer. It wasn't 'til she went to Atlantic. But he told me all those stories, and what a guy. But I talk about it in my class, in 1935 when he convinced Benny Goodman to hire Teddy Wilson, which I said would be equivalent to, I don't know, whoever's out there now, Hammond sending a man from Mars. It was front page. Not entertainment section, it was front page. "Goodman Breaks the Color Barrier." I've got the headlines on film and stuff. But that was twelve years before Jackie Robinson went into the major leagues. It was music that integrated first. Now before that, black and white musicians were getting together up in Harlem and playing at night at these joints Mel Powell and them told me about. They just couldn't tell anybody. They couldn't tell the sponsors, or people about it. Otherwise they'd be blackballed.

MR: Plus they were playing together on recordings, right?

SB: It wasn't 'til Hammond that they played integrated sessions.

MR: Then he hired —

SB: I've got pictures Mr. Hammond gave me of John Hammond leading a section. It was Benny Goodman; Freddie Green, Basie's guitarist; Basie playing piano; Buck Clayton playing trumpet. It was an integrated band. But Goodman, John Hammond told me, Goodman couldn't let other people know about that. Otherwise the band would be banned for integrating, behind the scenes. They played up in Harlem at nights, and places in LA. They were jamming. Especially in Harlem. But it was in '35 when Hammond convinced Benny to hire Teddy Wilson, that they integrated. And that became headline news. Yup. It was music who integrated society. And like you say, the white kids, all they cared about was we love this music. Back then, and when I was playing a lot, in the 60s and when it was white kids going to those dances. They weren't integrated dances for the most part. They were white audiences or we'd play in black clubs with black artists and black audiences.

MR: This could be an impossible question but as we wrap up here, you are at a cocktail party and you mention this course you teach and someone asks you well what makes black music black music?

SB: Well that is a good question. But Duke Ellington had a great answer. He said, "Great music is great music, no matter what. I don't care if it's country, jazz, pop, big band. Great music is great music." And that's really the way it is. And I know, I think, in my prime I could play black music as good as anybody. And I certainly worked — the guys in Muscle Shoals, that was an all-white rhythm section that played on all those massive Aretha hits. That sounded as black as anything could sound. So I don't think it's the color of your skin, it's like Booker T and the MGs in Memphis — two white guys and two black guys. And they played on Otis Redding, Sam & Dave, Rufus and Carla Thomas, all

those great records. It was an integrated rhythm section. But that was a segregated — Memphis was certainly a segregated city in the 60s. It was rough. But it was Booker T and the MGs. Booker T Jones, black, on keyboards; Al Jackson on drums, black; Steve Cropper, white, on guitar; and Duck Dunn, white, on bass. But that was as black as a — I mean that was really deep funk soul music.

MR: I remember getting fooled on a Paul Simon record. I said, that's got to be Richard T. And it wasn't. It was the guy from Muscle Shoals.

SB: Barry Beckett.

MR: Yeah it was Barry.

SB: Barry was a dear friend of mine. He died ten years ago or so. But yeah, I know Richard T and I know all those players. Cornell Dupree was one of my idols in New York on guitar — "Rainy Night in Georgia" and all that stuff. But Richard T was obviously magnificent as were a lot of guys. But Barry Beckett was as good as anybody. Paul Simon's "Still Crazy After All These Years" where it's just Barry on the Fender-Rhodes, and Paul Simon. And Barry told me that Paul made him do it in every key. I mean every key: A, B flat, B, C, C sharp. He had to play it in every — and if you listen to "Still Crazy After All These Years" it's not an easy chord progression, just the — Barry wrote his numbers out. That's the great thing about a number chart. You can write the numbers out and then okay I'll play it in A. Now let's do it in B flat. I still read the same numbers I just go up a half a step. That was the great thing about a number chart. So he played all those versions of "Still Crazy" for Paul Simon from a number chart. And when it was over Paul Simon picked the take and when he listened to it, it's a classic. And like I say he could play as good as anybody. Richard T or any of those guys. And I saw all the great ones. When I first saw Aretha in '69 it was the King Curtis band. Cornell Dupree, Jerry Jemmott on bass, Billy Preston on organ, and Richard T on electric piano and a great horn — the drummer was Bernard Purdie, Pretty Purdie.

MR: You couldn't get anybody good.

SB: No. And besides the New York horn section they brought in the Memphis horns. Two white guys and a black guy from Memphis to play. It was an unbelievable band. They opened the show and then Aretha comes on. And that's the same thing when you see Aretha live, the record "Aretha Live at the Filmore West" when Ray Charles came. That was that band. Yeah. Billy Preston playing organ for God's sakes. I mean, but I saw all those guys play. And Tom Scott did one in New York called the New York Connection with Pretty Purdie and all those guys. He'd hang up a sign when he was playing a session, whatever it was, his 15,101 session. He'd have a little sign he'd hang up every — there'd be a different sign.

MR: Tom Scott would?

SB: Tom Scott did an album there, it was the LA Express of course. They did the Joni Mitchell stuff. But then he went to New York and did one called the New York Connection with all those guys.

MR: Right. With Bernard Purdie.

SB: Well I don't know if it was Pretty Purdie, or it may have been Steve Gadd. That's who it was. That was the drummer.

MR: Who finally won a Grammy by the way.

SB: Steve Gadd?

MR: Steve Gadd did.

SB: He never won a Grammy?

MR: Nope. He won one.

SB: This year?

MR: This last, yes.

SB: We used to call him Bad Steve Gadd. Because he had this lick with the hi-hat that was like impossible. I mean it was like 16th, 32nd notes, I mean it was this crazy thing he could do with his left hand on the hi-hat. Bad Steve Gadd. I'm sure he's still bad too.

MR: Well I want to tell you I've really enjoyed this conversation.

SB: Me too.

MR: I know you have some people waiting for you.

SB: I don't think it's anything but dinner.

MR: So we'll book Part Two down the — conversation down the road.

SB: I hope I'm going to be back, but this is good, and it's good to talk to somebody who knows it, understands it, and I'm not talking about, again, jazz — I love jazz, I played, I produced jazz artists. I love great country music. I love great rhythm & blues. I love great pop music. Like Duke Ellington said, it's only great music. It's either good or it's bad. It doesn't matter what you label it. It's good or bad. And I appreciate the fact that you understand that.

MR: Well on that note, thanks a lot. Appreciate it.